widow, Jahan Begum, the daughter of Abdur Rahim, grieved him endlessly and lived each day of her long widowhood as if it were the first.

Salim stayed on at Agra, watching his father and his sons with cold calculation. In a discordant use of his energies at such a politically sensitive time, he appeared to become entirely obsessed with art, and the European paintings that were available to him. He continued to maintain warm relations with the Jesuits, ‘with whom he was on very intimate terms’. They offered the prince holy images and Salim had all their images copied by skilled painters. He had the image of a crucified Christ engraved on to a large emerald, the size of a quail’s egg, which he liked to wear attached to a gold chain. Xavier offered Salim a copy of the *Mirror of Purity*, which the prince read cover to cover. It was only the arrival of an Englishman, one John Mildenhall, that disrupted these harmonious exchanges.

The arrival of Europeans from now on in ever greater numbers was due to the enormous allure of the manufactured goods of Hindustan. Indeed, the entire region was one of the great centres of manufacturing, much before the coming of the Industrial Revolution in Europe. Traders and adventurers came in search of textiles and other finished goods, and visited cities that were among the wealthiest and most populous in the world, with a huge task force of skilled artisans. Indian swords and daggers were considered the best to be had anywhere and steel bows, requiring high quality metal and exceptional craftsmen, were a specialty of the country*. Travellers were also amazed at the purity of the coins manufactured. When an attempt had been made in 1599 to set up a charter for the establishment of an East India Company in London to exploit the great possibilities for trade in the East, Queen Elizabeth I had been reluctant, unwilling to risk the peace treaty with Spain which appeared imminent. But there were some who were emboldened at the thought of the riches to be made in the ‘Orient’, one of whom was a certain John military innovations. Mildenhall believed that if he could secure trading privileges with the East to equal those of Portugal, he would be richly rewarded for his troubles when he returned to England. With this unshakeable optimism, a letter from Queen Elizabeth I, and the fictitious title of ambassador, he set off for Hindustan.

At the Mughal court in Agra, Mildenhall was well received by Akbar, to whom he presented twenty-nine good horses as well as ‘diverse jewels, rings and earrings to his great liking’. Akbar appointed a house for his use and was his usual gracious self. It may be assumed that Mildenhall was